The 25th Annual Putnam County Spelling Bee

By Rachel Sheinkin, William Finn and Rebecca Feldman

CONEYBEAR: **(Pg 11-12)** *(Phone rings . . . Leaf Coneybear answers)* Hello, Leaf speaking. *(with growing excitement)* Uh, huh. Uh, huh, Uh, huh! Wow! *(puts hand over receiver and yells to his family)* Mom! Dad! Marigold, Brook, Pinecone, Raisin, Landscape, Paul – you're not going to believe this! I made the county finals in the spelling bee!

******Scene******

RONA: [Welcome to the] **(Pg 5)** 25th Annual Putnam County Spelling Bee **(Pg 7)** Hello, I'm Rona Lisa Peretti, and I'm pleased to be your host. Unfortunately, our usual word pronouncer, Superintendent Spriggs has *[fallen ill]*,* so please join me in welcoming back Vice Principal Douglas Panch.

**[Ad lib note: "fallen ill" can be replaced with a topical or local reference, ex: "Is quarantined with COVID-19 like symptoms]*

PANCH: **(Pg 8)** *(clearly infatuated with Rona)* Thank you, Rona, and I would like to say as to the incident 5 years ago, I'm in a much better place now.

RONA: And now for the official spelling bee rules.

PANCH: **(Pg 9-10)** A speller may ask questions about the word's pronunciation or definition, and use in a sentence. If you start to spell a word, you may start over,

PANCH AND A SPELLER: but the sequences of letters already spoken may not be changed.

RONA: If you misspell a word, we will ring the bell. *(Ding)* and the comfort counselor will escort you off stage!

PANCH: So, is that understood spellers?

OLIVE AND BARFEE: Yes

OLIVE: **(Pg 7)** What school do you go to?

BARFEE: Shut up!

PANCH: **(Pg 10)** Then, without further ado, let the spelling begin.

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INTRODUCTION

The 25th Annual Putnam County Spelling Bee by Rachel Sheinkin, William Finn and Rebecca Feldman

PANCH: **(Pg 10-11)** Miss Schwartzandgrubenierre . . .

RONA: Miss Schwartzandgrubenierre is the head of the Gay-Straight Alliance at her elementary school!

PANCH: STRABISMUS

SCHWARZY: *(with a pronounced lisp and other facial and body tics)* Strabismus. May I please have the definition of that word?

PANCH: "The inability of one eye to obtain binocular vision with the other because of an imbalance of the muscles of the eyeball."

SCHWARZY: And use in a sentence please?

PANCH: "In the schoolyard Billy protested that he wasn't cockeyed. 'I suffer from strabismus,' he said, whereupon the bullies beat him harder.

SCHWARZY: Strabismus. S-T-R-A-B-I-S-M-U-S. Strabismus.

PANCH: That is correct . . . Mr. Coneybear.

RONA: Mr. Coneybear **(Pg 18)** is recovering from headlice.

PANCH: **(Pg 12-13)** CAPYBARA

CONEYBEAR: What? Is that a word? What does it mean?

PANCH: "A tailless largely aquatic South American rodent often exceeding four feet in length"

CONEYBEAR: Oh . . . can you use it in a sentence?

PANCH: Yes. "Don't look now, Pedro, but I think that tailless, largely aquatic four-and-a-half foot rodent swimming next to you may be a capybara."

CONEYBEAR: Wow, that didn't help at all! C-A-P-Y-B-A-R-A. Capybara.

PANCH: This is correct. . . Miss Ostrovsky.

RONA: Miss Ostrovsky came in second in her school's Halloween contest.

OLIVE: I was road-kill!

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PANCH: *(Selected from Audience Volunteer Words – Appendix #2 and instructions on page 16)*

APOOP

AUDIENCE SPELLER 1: **(Pg 11)** Can I have a definition

PANCH: *(from Appendix #2, Pg 85)* "Toward the back; to move astern on a boat"

AUDIENCE SPELLER 1: Could you use it in a sentence?

PANCH: *(from Appendix #2, Pg 85)* "Guido, the seasick Italian sailor said, 'Scusa me, boys, but I'm-a-gonna go apoop."

AUDIENCE SPELLER 1: Apoop. A-P-O-O-P. Apoop.

PANCH: **(Pg 19-21)** That is correct . . . Mr. Tolentino

RONA: Charlito "Chip" Tolentino is a little league pitcher with a wicked 22-mile an hour screwball!

PANCH: OMPHALOSKEPSIS

CHIP: Wait a second, didn't the [last girl] just get APOOP?

PANCH: Yes, and you got: Omphaloskepsis.

CHIP: Can that also be pronounced "omPHAloskepsis"?

PANCH: It can . . . . It would be WRONG.

CHIP: Omphaloskepesis. O . . M . . . P . . . H. . . A . . L-O-S-K-E-P-S-I-S. Omphaloskepsis.

PANCH: That is correct.

RONA: He rallies and nails it. That's what it means to be a champion!

PANCH: Mr. Coneybear . . . **(Pg 23)** CRAYON . . . That's correct.

CHIP: Come on!

SCHWARZY: *(Off stage)* Damn it!

PANCH: **(Pg 17)** Mr. Barfee

BARFEE: It's Barfee

RONA: **(Pg 33)** Mr. Barfee made it to the finals last year, but had to be eliminated for health related reasons.

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BARFEE: *(momentary flashback, a horrified BARFEE in the midst of an allergic reaction)* Were there peanuts in the brownies? Cause they said there wouldn't be no peanuts in the brownies!

PANCH: **(Pg 17-18)** LUGUBRIOUS

BARFEE: One moment please.

RONA: Okay watch this technique – He calls it the Magic Foot, and he's the only one I've ever seen use it. *(Barfee enacts)* He spells it out on the floor so he can get a visual an then speaks it outloud.

BARFEE: Lugubrious. L-U-G-U – Lugu! B-R-I-O-U-S – Lugubrious.

RONA: Incredible!

BARFEE: I know.

PANCH: **(Pg 10)** Miss Schwartzandgrubenierre . . . *(Selected from Audience Volunteer Words – Appendix #2 and instructions on page 16)* DENGUE

SCHWARZY: *(attempts a couple of pronunciations)* DENGUE? DENGUE? May I please have the definition of that word?

PANCH: *(from Audience Volunteer Words – Appendix #2, Pg 88)* "A disease transmitted by mosquitoes that causes headache and severe diarrhea.

SCHWARZY: And use in a sentence please?

PANCH: *(from Audience Volunteer Words – Appendix #2, Pg 88)* When the pediatrician asked Billy to describe the symptoms of his dengue, he said, "It's like there was a race out of my Tushy and everybody won."

SCHWARZY: D-E-N-G-U-E. Dengue

PANCH: That is correct. . . Mr. Tolentino . . .

RONA: Chip **(Pg 53)** has a sea anemone circus in his basement!

CHIP: **(Pg 32)** *(distracted by a beautiful girl)* Leaf . . . that girl in the second row in the fuzzy sweater? Is that your sister? **(Pg 36)** Marigold . . . Marigold Coneybear . . .

PANCH: Mr. Tolentino . . .

CHIP: *(caught up in his fantasy)* Sorry- Um . . . can you maybe skip me and ask me two later?

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PANCH: Why would you want to do that?

CHIP: I'd rather not say? *(awkwardly covering his zipper region)*

PANCH: **(Pg 37-38)** You can either take your turn now or forfeit.

CHIP: I'll take my turn now

PANCH: TITTUP. The word is TITTUP.

CHIP: *(Chip giggles, then squelches it)* Definition please

PANCH: It means "lively movement or behavior. It refers to the sound of horse's hooves – tittup, tittup, tittup. *(he demonstrates a little gallop while he repeats the words)*

CHIP: Tittup. T . . I . . T *(winks and points at Marigold in the audience)* U – Oh wait. Two T's. Backing up, T-I-T-T-U-P. Tittup. *(Ding)*

PANCH: I'm sorry. The correct spelling is T-I-T-T-U-P. If you start to spell a word you may start over . . .

RONA and PANCH: but the sequences of letters already spoken may not be changed.

CHIP: That's not fair. It got it right. I can't get out on a word I spelled right. I won last year!!!

BARFEE: **(Pg 44-45)** *(Jeering)* See you next year! *(Chip makes a motion toward him)* You could be disqualified for that – if you hadn't already been eliminated!

CHIP: You know something, Barf: I may have lost, but you are the biggest loser here! *(stomps off)*

BARFEE: Oh yeah? Well, that is a common misperception

OLIVE: Sorry about that – William, right? I'm Olive.

BARFEE: I know your name. Look, I do not need pity from a person named after a vegetable.

OLIVE: It's a fruit.

BARFEE: Well, it's a disgusting fruit! *(hurt, she begins to walk away)* I guess it's okay for a name though.

OLIVE: Did you know that if you switch the first two vowels in "Olive" it becomes "I love"?

BARFEE: Did you know that if you switch the first two vowels in "William" it becomes . . . "William"?

OLIVE: Oh . . . Well, you're a really great speller.

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BARFEE: Yeah? Thanks! *(Olive exits)* "Olive." "I love." – That's so . . . *(makes an exasperated sound)*

RONA: **(Pg 45-46)** Ladies and gentlemen . . . Our final spellers! Leaf Coneybear, Mr. William Barfee, Miss Olive Ostrovsky and Miss Logainne Schwartzandgrubenierre.

SCHWARZY: I'd like to take one moment to thank my two fathers who've been so supportive of me. Thank you, dads!!

PANCH: **(Pg 49)** Please spell INDICANT

SCHWARZY: Indicant. I-N-D-I-C-A-N-T

BARFEE: P-A-L-A-V-E-R

OLIVE: H-A-L-L-U-X

PANCH: **(Pg 27-28)** ACOUCHI

CONEYBEAR: A-what? *(beat)* At a spelling bee?! What's it mean?

PANCH: "A South American rodent of the genus Myoprocta, resembling an agouti"

CONEYBEAR: It's funny how I keep getting South American rodents.

PANCH: *(Deadpan)* Hilarious.

CONEYBEAR: **(Pg 29)** A-C-O-U-C-H-I. Acouchi.

PANCH: That is correct.

SCHWARZY: **(Pg 51-53)** *(Rapid pace)* Part of speech

PANCH: That is correct.

OLIVE: From the tupi?

BARFEE: Yes, of course.

RONA: That is correct.

PANCH: That is correct.

RONA: That is correct.

PANCH: I'm sorry, that is incorrect.

CONEYBEAR: *(Gasps!)* It is? *(deflated he exits)* Apple juice please!

PANCH: **(Pg 67)** Miss Schwarzandgrubeniere. Vug

SCHWARZY: Vug? That's the whole word?

PANCH: Vug.

SCHWARZY: Vug. V-U-G-G-H-E. Vugghe. (Ding)

PANCH: I'm sorry, the correct answer is V-U-G. Vug

SCHWARZY: *(near tears)* So simple? *(she exits)*

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RONA: **(Pg 68)** How exciting! Will the final two spellers please step forward. *(Olive and Barfee step forward)*

PANCH: **(Pg 71-72)** Miss Ostrovsky – Elanguescence.

OLIVE: Elanguescence . . . *(Olive freezes)*

BARFEE: Hey Olive, don't think I'm distracted by your eyes and your smile and your hairdo . . .

OLIVE: *(looking at Barfee, she misses on purpose)* E-L-A-N-G-U-E-S-S-E-N-C-E *(Ding)*

PANCH: That's incorrect.

RONA: No speller can win on another's speller's mistake. Mr. Barfee must spell the next word correctly to take the Putnam Bee!

PANCH: William. Spell Weltanschauung.

BARFEE: Of course, Weltanschauung. *(doing his foot spelling technique)* W-E-L-T-A-N-S-C-H-A- *(He freezes)*

OLIVE: **(Pg 73-74)** Mama, I made a friend. I am fine with second.

BARFEE: S-C-H-A-U *(he looks over at Olive)*

OLIVE: It's okay, Barf.

BARFEE: U-N-G Weltanschauung

PANCH: We have a winner! **(Pg 75)** On behalf of our sponsors, we'd like to present you with this two-hundred-dollar savings bond toward your future education.

BARFEE: All my life I have only been able to breathe through one nostril and today is NOT an exception!

OLIVE: **(Pg 76)** Congratulations!!!

BARFEE: *(said with affection)* Shut up!

****** Epilogues******

PANCH: **(Pg 76-78)** Vice Principal Panch found a new passion in life -- Rona Lisa Peretti. After courting her tirelessly for over two years, she took out a restraining order on him.

RONA: Rona Lisa Perretti left Putnam County and traveled the world to bring competitive spelling to the less fortunate. She fell in love with an indigenous cashew farmer . . .

CHIP: Chip Tolentino made it through adolescence!

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CONEYBEAR: Leaf Coneybear has cats!

SCHWARZY: Logainne Schwartzandgrubenierre won the 31st annual Putnam County Spelling Bee. She went on to become Secretary of Education under President [insert president's name here] *(dropping her lisp)* Her speech therapy was successful!

BARFEE: William Morris Barfee grew up to be incredibly handsome!

OLIVE: Olive Ostrovsky grew up to be the host of her own radio talk show, where every year she interviewed the runner-up of the Putnam County Spelling Bee.

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AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier - MS
2019 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
2025 National Qualifier
2025 National Qualifier – MS
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